Chengezi, did not allow for ‘absolutism’: ‘In the empire founded by Ghengiz Khan the principle in force was that “the empire belonged not to the ruler, but to the ruling family”.’[8] Thus, any of the many Chagatais among Babur’s commanders had equal rights to Babur’s rule.

With that rapid, furious march to Adham’s court in Sarangpur – even more than with the furious fist to Adham’s face – Akbar had indicated that his ideas of rulership did not match his predecessors’. In the years to come, Akbar would march out with his army many times, to the deserts of Rajasthan and the seas of Gujarat, eastwards down the Ganga and southwards to the Deccan, up into the high valley of Kashmir and even back to Kabul – but his march would be most rapid and most furious not when he was embarking on a conquest of foreign land, but when he was out to subdue yet another obdurate chieftain unwilling to allow that Akbar was anything more than a lucky first among equals.

To the last man, they would realize they were wrong.

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The first of them, after Adham, was Sharafuddin, last seen menacing Raja Bihari Mal; and previously conspiring with Adham Khan to prevent Pir Muhammad’s exile. Now, both Adham and Pir Muhammad were dead, and Raja Bihari Mal was Akbar’s father-in-law, all of which may have raised apprehensions in Sharafuddin’s mind. Still, it isn’t as if Akbar planned a purge after Adham’s execution. Men who were far more closely and publicly allied with Adham Khan were spared. Munim Khan, for example, bore great suspicion of colluding with Adham in the murder of Shamsuddin – who was, after all, Munim Khan’s rival for the post of vakil. So convinced, in fact, was Munim of receiving his share of blame and punishment for Akbar’s ataka’s death that he fled the court, and was well on his way to Kabul when he was caught. Back in Agra, however, Akbar wasn’t inclined to linger on the past; he made no investigations into Munim’s conduct, he did not even keep him under probationary scrutiny. Instead, he received his khan-khanan ‘with boundless favours’[9] and gave him a promotion, allowing him Shamsuddin’s office of vakil.

Sharafuddin, too, was left undisturbed in Rajasthan. A few months after the Adham affair, he came to Agra with his father, one Khwaja Mu’in from